

War in the Iron Triangle

In 1967, US forces attacked North Vietnamese and Viet Cong strongholds in the border region northwest of Saigon. General Westmoreland's plan was to push enemy fighters into less populated areas, where US air power could demolish them.

◀◀ BEFORE

Binh Duong province had been a stronghold for insurgents since the days of French rule in Vietnam.

SECRET CHANNELS

The Viet Minh built a tunnel network in Binh Duong province during the [First Indochina War](#). After the partition of the country at the end of that war North Vietnam began sending men and supplies along the [Ho Chi Minh Trail](#) to insurgents building a stronghold there.

SEARCH-AND-DESTROY

In 1966, General Westmoreland, commander of US forces in Vietnam since June 1964, introduced a strategy known as [search-and-destroy](#).

The Iron Triangle was an area of approximately 120 square miles (310 sq. km) in the Binh Duong province, just a few hours' drive from Saigon. North Vietnamese forces and Viet Cong insurgents enjoyed strong support from local villagers in the area, and the Viet Cong had invested heavily in a fortified tunnel complex in the area of Cu Chi. The tunnels, like the Iron Triangle as a whole, provided a staging area for North Vietnamese and Viet Cong attacks on US and South Vietnamese units in the region and also on Saigon itself.

American forces made three major assaults on the Iron Triangle over a nine-month period between the fall of 1966 and May 1967. Operation Attleboro began in September 1966, Operation Cedar Falls in January 1967, and Operation Junction City lasted from February to May 1967.

Operation Attleboro

The main aim of Operation Attleboro was to destroy NVA and Viet Cong supply lines in the Iron Triangle. It developed into a major confrontation between a force of around 6,000 Viet Cong and NVA regulars and 22,000 US and ARVN troops. A series of intense battles over nearly three weeks resulted in heavy Viet Cong and NVA casualties (more than 1,000) and the seizure of oil stores, weapons, communication equipment, documents, and 2 million pounds (907,000 kg) of rice. However, as proved to be the case in most search-and-destroy operations, the Viet Cong chose to disengage from the fight when it was expedient to do so—in this case fleeing to sanctuaries across the Cambodian border. Once American forces had withdrawn from the area, Viet Cong and North Vietnamese forces simply returned.

Cedar Falls

Operation Cedar Falls was one of the largest American operations of the Vietnam War, involving some 30,000 US and ARVN troops. It relied on a "hammer-and-anvil" maneuver, in which some American forces were stealthily positioned to block an enemy retreat (the anvil) while others (the hammer) effectively drove the enemy through the jungle toward them. The battle plan also reversed the usual search-and-destroy methods by using American units to destroy suspected enemy villages, and then employing South Vietnamese units to detain and interrogate survivors. At the same time, Cedar Falls